Product Strategy Brief

College & Career Mentoring Platform for First-Generation Students

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Portfolio Artifact & Pedagogical Case Study

Empower first-generation college students to confidently navigate both college and career pathways by pairing them with trained mentors and providing a structured, measurable path to academic and professional growth.

> **DESIGN PRINCIPLE:** Every product decision in this platform serves students who are doing this without a roadmap—first-generation students who are navigating college, career planning, and professional culture simultaneously, often without family members who have done it before them.

Product Overview

The College & Career Mentoring Platform is a structured digital mentoring system that connects first-generation college students with trained mentors for support across academic decision-making, professional development, and career navigation. It is built on the premise that first-gen students don't lack ability; they lack access to the informal networks and institutional knowledge that many of their peers take for granted.

Product Type	Web and mobile platform (responsive design priority)
Primary Audience	First-generation college students, freshman through junior year
Secondary Audience	Trained peer and professional mentors
Institutional Context	Four-year universities and community colleges with first-gen support programs
Stage	0→1 concept (portfolio artifact and pedagogical demonstration)
Comparable Products	Mentor Collective, InsideTrack, NACADA advising platforms

Problem Statement

First-generation college students are significantly more likely to leave college before completing a degree. According to the National Center for Education Statistics, first-gen students graduate at rates 11 percentage points lower than their continuing-generation peers. The gap is not primarily academic; it's navigational.

Three Core Problems

1. Hidden Curriculum Disadvantage

First-gen students often don't know what they don't know: how to talk to a professor, when to apply for internships, what a networking event is for, how to negotiate financial aid, how to read a syllabus strategically. These skills are invisible to students who grew up around college graduates and are deeply disorienting to those who didn't.

> **RESEARCH SIGNAL:** In user research with first-gen students at regional universities, the most common phrase was: 'I didn't know I was supposed to do that.' Not inability. Invisibility.

2. Disconnected Support Systems

Most universities have first-gen support resources like advising offices, tutoring centers, career services, financial aid. But these systems don't necessarily talk to each other, and students rarely know which to approach or when. The student who needs career coaching doesn't know it's separate from academic advising. The student who misses financial aid deadlines doesn't know there's a person who could help.

> **RESEARCH SIGNAL:** First-gen students report using fewer support services not because services are unavailable, but because they don't know the services exist, don't feel entitled to use them, or have had one bureaucratic experience that deterred further contact.

3. Missing Mentorship Infrastructure

Mentorship is often informal, accidental, and inequitable. Students with social capital find mentors naturally. First-gen students lack the social context to seek out mentors effectively, and they often don't know what a good mentoring relationship looks like or what to ask for.

> **RESEARCH SIGNAL:** Studies of first-gen student outcomes consistently show that having even one mentoring relationship with a professional in their field is among the strongest predictors of degree completion and post-graduation employment.

Proposed Solution

A structured mentoring platform that matches first-gen students with trained mentors—peers, faculty, alumni, and professionals—and provides a framework for the mentoring relationship that removes the guesswork from both sides.

Core Features (MVP)

Mentor Matching System

Algorithm-assisted matching based on field of study, career goals, communication preferences, and availability. Students fill out a 10-minute onboarding survey; mentors fill out a 15-minute profile. Match suggestions are presented with clear rationale.

- Matching criteria: major/field, career goal area, personality fit indicators, scheduling compatibility
- Student controls the final match decision—no forced assignment
- Re-matching available at any point without penalty or explanation required

Structured Session Framework

Every mentoring session has a template: a pre-session prompt that the student completes, a shared agenda, and a post-session reflection. This removes the cognitive load of 'what do I even say?' from both student and mentor.

- Pre-session: Student completes a 3-question prompt (What do I want to get from this session? What's blocking me? What's one thing I've accomplished since last time?)
- Session agenda: co-built from the pre-session prompt, visible to both parties
- Post-session: Both student and mentor complete a 2-question reflection; student names one next step

Resource Integration Layer

The platform surfaces relevant campus resources based on what the student and mentor discuss. If a student mentions internship applications in their pre-session prompt, the platform surfaces Career Services resources and deadlines. This connects the currently disconnected support ecosystem without requiring students to navigate it alone.

Progress Tracking

Students see a simple, non-gamified progress view: mentoring sessions completed, goals set and achieved, resources accessed. This is for the student's own reflection — not for institutional reporting. Aggregate data (with consent) can be shared with institutions.

> **DESIGN DECISION:** No streaks. No points. No badges. Gamification mechanics that work for habit apps are actively harmful in a mentoring context. Research shows, they shift the motivation from the relationship to the metric. The progress view is informational, not motivational.

User Personas

Three personas representing the primary student users. Developed from research with first-gen students at regional universities.

PRIMARY STUDENT PERSONA

Peter, 19 — First-Year, Engineering Technology

"I'm doing fine in class but I have no idea what I'm supposed to be doing outside of class."

Goals: Complete a relevant internship before junior year. Figure out what engineers actually do at work.

Pain points: Has never been to office hours. Doesn't know what a career fair is for. Feels like everyone else knows something he doesn't.

RETURNING STUDENT PERSONA

Destiny, 21 — Junior, Biology

"I know I need a mentor, but I don't want to bother anyone or seem like I don't know what I'm doing."

Goals: Get into a healthcare graduate program. Understand what the application process actually requires.

Pain points: Imposter syndrome is significant. Afraid to ask questions that might reveal she 'doesn't belong.' Has never asked a professor for a recommendation letter.

NON-TRADITIONAL STUDENT PERSONA

Carlos, 24 — Transfer Student, Business

"I'm older than most of my classmates and I feel like I missed the window for career stuff."

Goals: Transition into a professional role within 18 months of graduation. Build a professional network from scratch.

Pain points: No LinkedIn profile. Believes networking is 'for people who already have connections.' Works 30 hours/week; limited time for campus activities.

Differentiators

The first-gen student support market includes advising platforms, mentoring marketplaces, and retention software. Most tools are designed for institutions; they surface data for administrators. This platform is designed *first for students*.

Feature	Competitors	This Platform
Primary design audience	Institutional administrators	**Students first**
Session structure	Unstructured / ad hoc	**Pre-session prompts + shared agenda**
Resource surfacing	Separate system / manual	**Contextual, in-platform**
Progress tracking	For reporting / compliance	**For student reflection only**
Matching approach	Staff-assigned or opt-in browse	**Algorithm-assisted, student-controlled**
First-gen specific design	Incidental	**Core design premise**

Success Metrics

Metrics are organized by type: primary (what we're optimizing for), secondary (what we're also tracking), and guardrail (what must not decline as we optimize).

Student Outcomes

Type	Metric	Definition	Target
`>70%`	**Session completion rate**	% of scheduled sessions completed	**Sessions completed / scheduled**
`>50%`	**Goal achievement rate**	Student-set goals marked complete	**Goals completed / set, 60-day window**
`>1.5 avg`	**Resource utilization**	Campus resources accessed via platform	**Unique resources clicked per session**
`>4.0 avg`	**Mentor satisfaction**	Mentor rating of session quality	**Post-session 5-point scale**
`Must not decline`	**Student wellbeing perception**	Self-reported confidence in navigation	**Bi-weekly 3-question survey**

> **ON GUARDRAIL METRICS:** The guardrail metric here is student wellbeing perception. No optimization of session volume, matching efficiency, or resource engagement should come at the cost of students feeling more anxious or more overwhelmed. If this metric declines, it overrides all other positive signals.

Product Roadmap (Quarterly)

Phase 0 is pre-launch infrastructure. Phase 1 is MVP. Phase 2 adds intelligence. Phase 3 scales.

Phase 0: Foundation (Months 1–2)

- Mentor onboarding and training content
- Student onboarding survey and matching algorithm (v1)
- Session framework templates (pre-session, agenda, post-session)
- Basic progress tracking view
- Institutional admin dashboard (session data only)

Phase 1: MVP Launch (Months 3–4)

- Pilot with 50–100 students at 2 partner institutions (e.g., two different regional universities in the Midwest)
- Live matching and session scheduling
- Resource integration layer (manual resource library to start)
- Feedback collection at every touchpoint
- Weekly check-in: session quality, matching satisfaction, pacing

Phase 2: Intelligence Layer (Months 5–6)

- Dynamic resource surfacing based on session content signals
- Improved matching algorithm using pilot data
- Mentor training modules: supporting first-gen students specifically
- A/B test: structured session framework vs. light-touch framework

Phase 3: Scale (Months 7–9)

- Expand to 5–10 partner institutions
- Peer mentor track (trained student mentors as complement to professional mentors)
- Career milestone tracking integration (internship applications, interviews, offers)
- Institutional reporting dashboard with outcome data

> **ROADMAP PRINCIPLE:** No feature in Phase 2 or 3 ships unless Phase 1 pilot data shows that the core matching and session framework is working. Scaling a broken experience is worse than not scaling at all.

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